



Jancarik's triumph propelled him up 134 places to World No. 40, according to the latest rankings released on February 16. The victory earned him \$17,000 in prize money (₹15.48 lakh) and 600 ranking points — rewards that reflect the magnitude of his achievement given the quality of the field.

An overwhelmed Jancarik admitted he was still processing the moment in the immediate aftermath of his win. "I am not really realising what just happened at the moment. I think the energy of India and the people — I like it here, that's it. I am blessed. Nobody expected I would win the tournament," he told *Sportstar*.

He also pointed to broader changes back home. Table tennis in the Czech Republic is gradually improving after the appointment of new coach Salvador Uribe of Mexico, he added. "The sport is getting more and more popular. And the important thing is that after the arrival of Uribe, we are slowly getting the structure [in place]. I think the future will be better," said Jancarik.

The tournament was the first major international event to be held at a new High-Performance Centre (HPC) for table tennis established by the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT) in collaboration with India's star paddler Sharath Kamal.

The facility, inaugurated last November, marks a significant step forward for the sport in the State. It is located at the Tamil Nadu Physical Education and Sports University (TNPESU), a vast 125-acre campus on the southern outskirts of Chennai whose infrastructure includes football and hockey fields, a cricket ground, an athletics track, courts for kabaddi, kho-kho, ball badminton, tennikoit, handball and volleyball, a velodrome, and a state-of-the-art biomechanics and sports science laboratory.

Sharath said the HPC reflects the next phase of the sport. The 43-year-old insisted he wanted it to be not just a competitive venue, but much more. "In collaboration with the Table Tennis Federation of India (TTFI), I also intend to host national training camps for both juniors and seniors. The goal is to make the Centre a regular hub for elite preparation," he said. One of its most important objectives, he elaborated, is to develop players from Tamil Nadu who can rise to the highest levels of international sport and win medals on the world stage.

The HPC, he said, will provide top-class, holistic training for paddlers. "Our focus will be on technical excellence, tactical intelligence, physical conditioning, mental and psychological preparation, sports science and

Mixed mastery: India's standout performance came in mixed doubles, where Harmeet Desai and Yasashwini Ghorpade fought their way to the final before losing to Eduard Ionescu and Bernadette SZOCS. PICS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

recovery, athlete education and life skills, and long-term athlete development."

During the tournament, meticulous arrangements were made to ferry players and officials to and from their hotels. The logistics ran like clockwork, but spectator turnout was minimal. With a seating capacity of around 700, the venue was largely filled by family members and friends of players and officials. There is optimism that once metro rail connectivity to the area is established in the coming years, larger crowds will attend major tournaments at the venue. That said, in terms of quality and organisation, the event signalled promise for Chennai's growing stature in table tennis. Sharath is expected to play a pivotal role in it. As Somnath Ghosh, Sreeja Akula's coach, said: "He is the face of TT in India."

With the WTT Youth Contender (October 23-26) and WTT Feeder (October 28 to November 1) scheduled at TNPESU, awareness of both the sport and the venue is set to grow further.